

COUNTRYSIDE CONCERNS Farmers blocking railway tracks at Shambhu in Punjab, Apr. 17

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alienation and corresponding anger against the BJP began after Manohar Lal Khattar, a Punjabi Khatri, was chosen as chief minister in 2014. The past decade also witnessed aggravating events other than the protests against the now-repealed agricultural laws, like the violent 2016 Jat quota agitation and the wrestlers' stir in Delhi, which had Haryana's khap panchayats rallying behind female Jat grapplers. Mobilising around former Congress chief minister Bhupinder Singh Hooda, community leaders are now backing the farm unions blocking the entry of his rivals in Jat-dominated villages. Similar scenes are playing out in Punjab as well, where farmers plan to stage protests wherever Prime Minister Narendra Modi is scheduled to campaign.

45
PER CENT
Share of labour force enganged in farming/ allied activities

16
PER CENT
Agriculture sector's contribution to GDP

4
PER CENT
The sector's annual growth rate in the past 20 years

Why the Farmers Matter

As the general election enters its last leg—Haryana votes on May 25 and Punjab on June 1—both the BJP and the Opposition have realised the alienation that pervades the farming community across the country, even though it may be manifesting more aggressively in the northern states. A fact that often tends to get overlooked is that farmers comprise the biggest voting bloc in India, often trumping caste, another important determining factor in Indian politics. And why is it so? For one, defining voters in terms of this economic category has a cohesive effect, rather than a fragmenting one. The social blocs that make up the other backward class (OBC) are often in competition with each other on the ground; so stoking ambitions